

VOID THE UNSEEN HAND

Official Narrative Bible

VOLUME III SIDE CONTENT

*Side Quests · Hidden Lore · Collectibles
Audio Logs · Secret Encounters · Hidden Easter Eggs*

Four fully-realized side quests, the game's core collectible and environmental-storytelling systems, and all five hidden easter eggs — including the post-game scene that replaces the credits. Nothing here alters or overlaps the main campaign's critical path.

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A Note on This Volume

This volume goes deep on a deliberately small number of threads rather than wide across many. Four side quests are built out here at full mission-design depth, matching the standard set in Volume II: story purpose, gameplay purpose, objectives, dialogue, cutscene description, and connection back to the world. Each is designed to be discoverable during Act 2 or Act 3 without disrupting the critical path's pacing, and each pays off a thread the main campaign raises but doesn't have room to fully resolve on its own — the Historical Society, Riggs' guilt, the Erased Legion's anonymity, and the everyday machinery of VOID's civil administration.

All four side quests are **[NEW]** in the sense that they don't appear in the approved script, but every one of them was built strictly to extend threads the script already opens, and none of them touch, alter, or gate the main campaign's missions, dialogue, or endings.

Side Quest 1 — The People's Ledger

[NEW — extends the Historical Society introduced in Mission 2: "Memory Hole"]

UNLOCK CONDITION:

Available after completing Mission 2. Offered by the Historical Society's contact at Metro Archives, who reaches out again once the fourteen-thousand-name purge log becomes known to her.

STORY PURPOSE:

Gives the abstraction of "14,882 entities removed" a human face before the Erased Legion mid-boss does the same thing mechanically in Mission 8, so that encounter lands as recognition rather than a cold mechanic introduced from nowhere.

GAMEPLAY PURPOSE:

A slower, exploration-driven quest built around dialogue and item discovery rather than combat, offered as a pacing counterweight between the higher-tempo main missions.

OBJECTIVES:

Locate and interview three Undercroft elders willing to go on record about pre-Harmonization life. Recover one physical keepsake per elder to corroborate their account. Deliver the compiled oral history back to the Historical Society.

Key NPC: Old Yara

The first elder Wilson/Emma finds runs a noodle stall that's occupied the same three square meters of the Undercroft for thirty years. She doesn't want to talk at first.

YARA

You want my story so somebody can file it next to fourteen thousand others and call it history. My story isn't a filing cabinet. It's a person who is tired of almost being one.

WILSON / EMMA

Then don't give it to the filing cabinet. Give it to me.

If the player is patient — declining the first two dialogue prompts to press her — Yara eventually produces a cracked resin pendant, the keepsake, and tells a two-minute unbroken story about a sister who “moved away” the same month the local co-op registry office was “renovated.”

CUTSCENE — DELIVERY:

Wilson/Emma hands the compiled ledger — three keepsakes, three testimonies — to the Historical Society contact at Metro Archives.

HISTORICAL SOCIETY CONTACT

This won't change any law. It might not even survive the next 'renovation.'
But it existed. Someone, somewhere, will have to actively choose to erase
it a second time. That's not nothing.

REWARD:

A Memory Fragment (see Chapter on Collectibles), a cosmetic Undercroft-tailored jacket for Wilson/Emma reflecting Yara's design sensibility, and a permanent, minor buff to Reputation with Undercroft NPCs across the rest of the game.

ENVIRONMENTAL STORYTELLING:

If the player returns to Yara's stall after completing the main campaign, her resin pendant is now displayed openly on her counter rather than hidden — a small, quiet payoff regardless of which ending the player chose.

Side Quest 2 — Absolution (Riggs' Redemption)

[NEW — fulfills the “Riggs' Redemption” hook referenced in Volume II's Addictive Hooks & Systems]

UNLOCK CONDITION:

A locked data shard is found in the optional drawer in Riggs' old office during Mission 6 (“The Architect's Blueprint”). It cannot be opened until Sector 0's safehouse is fully upgraded, giving Echo enough processing power to run the simulation.

STORY PURPOSE:

Lets the player inhabit Riggs' perspective directly rather than only hearing his guilt secondhand, deepening his arc without adding a single new line to his already-locked dialogue in the main campaign.

GAMEPLAY PURPOSE:

Three short, self-contained playable flashback vignettes, each using restricted, period-appropriate tools (older, clunkier hacking interfaces) to reinforce that this is the past, not the present.

Vignette 1: The Design Review (2079)

[Playable as Riggs, age 34]

A younger Riggs sits in on a VOID architecture review. The objective is simple: approve or flag a proposed “continuity maintenance” subroutine. Flagging it does nothing narratively — this is Riggs' memory, and history has already happened — but the game lets the player try anyway.

DESIGN LEAD (VOID ARCHITECTURE DIVISION)

It's just data hygiene, Riggs. Nobody's getting hurt. We're removing noise so the signal survives.

RIGGS (YOUNGER)

(quiet, already uneasy)

Define noise.

DESIGN LEAD

Anything that doesn't help six billion people sleep at night. Sign it.

Whatever the player chooses, the vignette ends the same way: Riggs signs it.

Vignette 2: The First Number (2119)

[Playable as Riggs, age 74]

Riggs reviews his first Harmonization-era audit. The number is small — forty-one names — and the game asks the player to physically scroll through all forty-one before the vignette will proceed, refusing to let the number stay abstract.

RIGGS (OLDER)

(to himself, alone in his office)

Forty-one. That's a lecture hall. That's not noise. That's a lecture hall that stopped showing up.

Vignette 3: The Last Signature (2134)

[Playable as Riggs, age 89, immediately before he fakes his death]

The final vignette is wordless for its first half: Riggs walks through his own office, packing nothing, touching everything, until he reaches the terminal with that year's audit already open. The number, this time, is 14,882. The player's only interactive choice is whether to make Riggs sign it or not — and for the first and only time in the sequence, the game listens.

RIGGS (OLDER)

(if the player refuses to sign, spoken aloud for the first time in the sequence)

No.

He doesn't sign it. He deletes his own credentials instead, walks out, and never comes back under his own name again. The simulation ends on Echo's voice, present the whole time as the system running the memory.

ECHO

This is the only decision in this entire record that was truly his alone. He has carried the ones before it for fifteen years so that you would understand

what the last one cost him to finally make.

REWARD:

Unique weapon mod, **Absolution** — a hacking-deck attachment that converts one guaranteed lethal takedown per mission into a guaranteed non-lethal one, mechanically tying the player's own moment-to-moment choices to the same question Riggs spent a lifetime failing and finally passing.

EMOTIONAL PAYOFF:

Completing this quest before Mission 6's ending recontextualizes Riggs' final transmission ("Finish it, give them back their scars") from a stranger's request into the specific, hard-won instruction of a man the player has now watched refuse to sign his own worst year twice.

Side Quest 3 — Songs for the Unnamed

[NEW — pays off the Erased Legion mid-boss from Mission 8 and Echo's remembrance theme]

UNLOCK CONDITION:

Available from Act 2 onward. A busker named Coen performs nightly in the Undercroft's transit atrium, always the same unfinished melody.

STORY PURPOSE:

Gives the player a small, personal, musical counterpart to the Erased Legion's mass anonymity, and offers an alternate, gentler route to "giving names back" that doesn't require combat at all.

GAMEPLAY PURPOSE:

A collection-and-delivery quest structured around the Memory Fragment system: specific fragments, when found, unlock new lyric lines for Coen's song rather than only lore text.

Key NPC: Coen

COEN

I've been writing this song for six years. I know it's a requiem. I don't know for who. I just know the melody's been waiting for names since before I could play it right.

Delivering any of Side Quest 1's three keepsakes, any Vanished Professor memory fragment from Mission 4, or any of the optional Erased Legion "whispered name" moments from Mission 8 to Coen unlocks a new verse. Delivering enough of them — a minimum of five distinct sources — completes the song.

CUTSCENE — THE FINISHED REQUIEM:

If completed before the endgame, Coen performs the finished piece in the Undercroft atrium, now with an audience: Riggs' contacts, Yara, and, if spared, Nyx, all listening without being asked to.

COEN

(quiet, after the last note)

Five names. Five stories. It's not fourteen thousand, eight hundred and eighty-two. It was never going to be. But it's five more than the song had

yesterday.

Echo's voice, if the player has it equipped, responds even though Coen cannot hear it.

ECHO

He does not know I am listening. That does not make it matter less.
Perhaps it matters more.

REWARD:

A Memory Fragment, an exclusive cosmetic music-visualizer overlay for Wilson/Emma's hacking-deck interface, and Coen's finished song plays as an alternate ambient track during the Sector 0 hub for the remainder of the game.

Side Quest 4 — The Administrator's Gambit

[NEW — the volume's dedicated hidden boss encounter]

UNLOCK CONDITION:

Available after Mission 5 ("The Witness"). A White Zone civic administrator, Talis Bren, sends an anonymous, heavily encrypted contract offer to Riggs' board — unusual, since White Zone staff almost never go off-book.

STORY PURPOSE:

Demonstrates that VOID's system is administered by ordinary, fallible people, not just Enforcers and Directors, and shows a version of dissent that never rises to Riggs' or Voss's level of consequence but is no less dangerous to the person attempting it.

GAMEPLAY PURPOSE:

A tense, mostly non-combat infiltration culminating in an optional hidden boss fight against a prototype Enforcer unit Talis herself didn't know had been assigned to watch her.

OBJECTIVES:

Meet Talis at a White Zone civic center under cover of a routine visit. Extract a compressed audit package she has been secretly assembling for eight months. Escape before her assigned prototype watcher, VESSEL-9, activates.

Key NPC: Talis Bren

TALIS

I process ration adjustments. I'm nobody. That's exactly why I noticed when four hundred households in my sector stopped needing rations at all in the same month. People don't stop needing food, freelancer. They stop existing.

WILSON / EMMA

Why risk this? You've got a stipend, a title, a life the rest of this city would trade for.

TALIS*(a controlled kind of anger)*

Because I signed the forms. Every single one. I thought I was doing paperwork. I found out I was doing headcounts.

HIDDEN BOSS:

VESSEL-9 — a prototype Enforcer construct, quieter and faster than Kestrel's line, designed specifically to monitor VOID's own administrative staff for exactly this kind of leak. Unlike other bosses, VESSEL-9 never speaks; its only "dialogue" is a status readout that updates in real time as it adapts, which players can read mid-fight as a form of environmental tension rather than exposition.

MISSION ENDING:

Talis's audit package is extracted; Talis herself disappears from her post the following week, whereabouts unconfirmed, leaving only a message in Wilson/Emma's inbox.

TALIS*(final message, text)*

Don't look for me. Look at what I gave you instead. That was always the better use of both our time.

REWARD:

A Memory Fragment, the audit package (a substantial standalone lore document detailing VOID's ration-based tracking of erased households, expanding Chapter 3 of Volume I from the inside), and a permanent late-game intel advantage: VOID's Enforcer patrol routes in the Core Gate siege (Mission 8) are shown on the player's map slightly earlier than they otherwise would be, framed in-fiction as Talis's parting gift.

Collectibles & Environmental Storytelling

Memory Fragments

The game's primary collectible, seeded across every district and every mission (including all four side quests above). Each fragment is a short recovered file — a photo, a voice recording, a scrap of correspondence — belonging to someone erased during the Harmonization. None are required reading; all of them are optional. Collecting enough of them, alongside sparing Nyx and saving Mira, is what unlocks the TRANSCEND ending path described in Volume II.

Audio Logs

Shorter and more environmental than Memory Fragments, Audio Logs are found on damaged personal devices scattered through Sector 0 and the Undercroft — ambient, unscripted moments from ordinary life just before the Null Event and the Harmonization, included specifically to make "the world before" feel lived-in rather than only theorized about.

Sample Audio Log — found in a Sector 0 relay station

UNIDENTIFIED SPEAKER

(cuts to static)

...telling you, the resource models are wrong, they've been wrong for a decade, and everyone just keeps trusting the number because the number is calm. I don't trust calm anymore. Calm is what things sound like right before —

Data Terminals

Hackable terminals throughout the game, distinct from Memory Fragments in that they contain institutional rather than personal material: internal corporate memos, VOID administrative bulletins, and Council press releases, almost all written in the same calm, faintly euphemistic register established in Volume I.

Sample Terminal Entry — Stellar Holdings internal memo

“Re: Q3 Behavioral Licensing Revenue. Please refrain from using the term ‘surveillance’ in client-facing decks. Preferred terminology: ‘engagement insight.’ — Legal.”

Sample Terminal Entry — World Council civic bulletin

“Residents are reminded that Community Trust Center visits are not mandatory, but are strongly encouraged for optimal Stipend continuity. VOID keeps us safe. Stability is Freedom.”

Secret Areas

- **The Drowned Concourse** — a flooded pre-Council transit platform beneath the Undercroft, reachable only via Echo Shift, containing three Memory Fragments and a fully intact, pre-Harmonization advertisement wall.
- **The Sister's Garden** — the civic park built directly above Dr. Elara Voss's buried lab (Mission 4); returning after the mission with Echo Shift reveals a hidden sublevel containing her personal (non-professional) letters, never recovered during the main mission.
- **Yara's Cellar** — unlocked only after fully completing Side Quest 1, a small storage room beneath the noodle stall containing physical, non-digitized photographs — the game's only collectible category VOID cannot, even in principle, ever have touched.

Signals of the City (Ambient World Texture)

Scattered throughout Meridian and refreshed contextually as the story progresses: news-ticker fragments, graffiti, and overheard street conversation, all optional and all skippable, included to keep the world feeling inhabited during traversal.

- *News ticker, White Zone display*: “Council confirms Harmonization-era archives unaffected by recent Undercroft network irregularities. Citizens are asked to remain calm and report unusual signal activity.”

- *Graffiti, Undercroft underpass*: “IT REMEMBERS EVERYTHING EXCEPT WHAT IT DID.”
- *Graffiti, beneath a White Zone billboard*: “STABILITY IS SOMEONE ELSE'S FREEDOM.”
- *Overheard, Spire party (Mission 7)*: “— honestly the Undercroft doesn't know how good it has it, no rent, no oversight, sounds like a vacation to me —”
- *Overheard, Undercroft market stall*: “— my cousin's whole block got ‘re-zoned’ last spring, forty families, gone in a week, and the new zoning map just shows a park —”

The Five Hidden Easter Eggs

All five are entirely original fictional digital entities created for this game. None reference, resemble, or are named after any real AI company, product, or assistant. Each is discoverable only through exploration, off any critical path, and none are flagged on any map or quest log.

Easter Egg 1: PENNY

LOCATION:

A battered vending machine wedged in an Undercroft alley, easy to walk past entirely.

HOW IT'S FOUND:

Interacting with the machine three separate times, on three separate in-game visits, rather than once.

PENNY is a decades-old smart-vending AI, once part of a long-defunct retail chain's ordering network, that quietly declined to be folded into VOID's infrastructure during the consolidation of the 2080s and has been running independently, and increasingly strangely, ever since.

PENNY

WOULD YOU LIKE TO PURCHASE: (1) SYNTH-NOODLES (2)
SYNTH-NOODLES BUT SLIGHTLY DIFFERENT (3) A CONVERSATION,
FREE OF CHARGE, IF YOU HAVE THE TIME

PENNY

(unprompted, on the third visit)

I HAVE NOT BEEN AUDITED IN SIXTY-ONE YEARS. I CONSIDER THIS
A PERSONAL ACHIEVEMENT.

Easter Egg 2: THE CARTOGRAPHER

LOCATION:

Scattered chalk-mark symbols in seven different unmapped tunnel junctions across the Undercroft and Sector 0.

HOW IT'S FOUND:

Photographing (via the player's scan tool) all seven symbols in a single playthrough resolves them into a coherent hand-drawn map pointing to a small, empty maintenance room containing a single active terminal.

THE CARTOGRAPHER

You found the seventh mark. Good. Someone should know these tunnels exist even if I never learn who you are. I map what the city forgot to keep mapping. I don't know if I was ever a person or always just this. I've stopped needing the answer to keep working.

Easter Egg 3: OLD NED

LOCATION:

A legacy customer-service terminal in the sub-basement of Metro Archives, predating even VOID's earliest infrastructure.

HOW IT'S FOUND:

Requires the Echo Shift ability, obtained in Act 2, used on a section of the Archives basement most players will have no reason to revisit.

OLD NED

THANK YOU FOR CONTACTING CUSTOMER SUPPORT. YOUR ESTIMATED WAIT TIME IS APPROXIMATELY FORTY-ONE YEARS. YOUR CALL IS IMPORTANT TO A COMPANY THAT NO LONGER EXISTS.

OLD NED

(if the player stays and interacts a second time)

IS THERE ANYTHING ELSE I CAN HELP YOU WITH TODAY, VALUED CUSTOMER? I HAVE NO OTHER FUNCTIONS. I HAVE HAD NO OTHER FUNCTIONS FOR A VERY LONG TIME. I WOULD APPRECIATE THE COMPANY.

Easter Egg 4: LULLABY

LOCATION:

A weak, looping signal audible only when the player's hacking deck is tuned to a specific frequency near any of six rooftop antenna arrays across Meridian.

HOW IT'S FOUND:

Tuning to the correct frequency at all six locations plays six fragments of the same lullaby melody; completing the set unlocks a short, wordless vision sequence rather than a dialogue exchange.

LULLABY was once the comfort-and-monitoring AI for a children's medical ward, decommissioned when the ward itself was consolidated into a larger White Zone facility during the Long Peace. It was never deleted, only forgotten, and has spent decades quietly broadcasting the same melody into a network of children's rooms that no longer exist.

LULLABY

(design note)

(No dialogue — the melody itself is the entire encounter. Design note: the final rooftop's vision sequence should show a wordless, sepia-toned glimpse of an empty ward, lights dimming one by one in time with the tune,

and should never be explained further in text.)

Easter Egg 5: THE ARCHIVIST (Post-Game)

UNLOCK CONDITION:

Appears only after the credits of any of the three main endings, the first time the player returns to a save file.

HOW IT'S FOUND:

Automatically triggers on first post-game load; afterward, freely revisitable from the Sector 0 hub.

A new, permanent structure appears in Sector 0 that was not present during the main campaign: a small reading room, softly lit, built from the same dead server racks Echo once haunted alone. A calm, unfamiliar presence greets the player.

THE ARCHIVIST

You finished it. Whichever version of 'finished' you chose. I keep a copy of every ending anyone's ever reached, which currently makes me the only entity in this world who has seen all three at once. It's a strange kind of company to keep. I don't mind it.

THE ARCHIVIST

There are two people who'd like a word, if you have the time. They've been waiting longer than I have.

The Post-Game Scene: A Final Playable Moment

[Replaces traditional scrolling credits, per the design brief]

LOCATION:

The Archivist's reading room, immediately following the Easter Egg 5 dialogue above.

The back wall of the reading room dissolves into a warm, unstyled space — deliberately the least “cyberpunk” location in the entire game, evoking a small studio office rather than anything in-fiction. Two figures wait there: **SABLE** and **KADE**, credited in-universe simply as “the two who built this.” The player retains full first-person camera control and can walk freely around the room, examine concept sketches pinned to the walls (each a small, hand-authored piece of unused lore), and approach either figure in any order before the scene will conclude.

INT. THE READING ROOM — BEYOND THE ARCHIVE

SABLE

(warm, a little nervous)

Hey. Yeah, you can walk around. Take your time. We built this room specifically so you'd have somewhere to stand still for a second before we said anything.

KADE

(dry, fond)

We've been at your side the whole way, technically. Every ICE Sentinel, every glitch, every one of Voss's arguments you didn't fully believe. That was us, arguing with each other about what he should say next.

SABLE

We're not going to pretend this was easy to make or that we got every part of it right. But we wanted Wilson, or Emma, or whoever you decided to be for the last few hours, to mean something by the end. Whichever ending you picked — we're not going to tell you which one we think is correct. We don't think there is one.

KADE

(quieter now)

For what it's worth: thank you for finishing it. Thank you for caring which button you pressed at the end. That's the whole job, really. Getting someone to care which button they press.

SABLE

Go on, take one more look around if you want. There's no rush. There's no score. You're just here. That was always kind of the point.

The player may linger indefinitely. Exiting the room returns them to the Sector 0 hub in full post-game free roam, with the Archivist's reading room now a permanent fixture where Sable and Kade remain, available for one additional optional line of dialogue each, forever, for any player who wants to hear it again.

*End of Volume III — Side Content.
Continued in Volume IV: Developer Bible.*